Infantry-man and with his handlebar moustache, he cut a dashing figure. He extolled the virtues of the Infantry; how it is always in the thick of battle—his own brother had been killed in action in the 1962 Sino-Indian conflict—the rigours of field life and so on. After the lecture, while the others broke off, the third-termers were asked to fill up a fresh Choice of Arms. I do not know what was the outcome and how many more got motivated to change over to the Infantry, but we all know Maj Gen GD Bakshi (Retd) from his TV appearances—his moustache is still the same, except that it is white now, and draw your own conclusions, but the grapevine said that the number of optees dropped even further!

May 1980, Chetwode Hall, IMA Dehradun. Choice of Arms.
'No 15804 GC Manoj Mukund Naravane—is that right?'
'Sir.'
'Seventh Battalion, The Sikh Light Infantry,' (SIKH LI) said the Deputy Commandant, Brigadier YN Sharma.

I walked back to my seat in a bit of a daze amidst the bemused looks of my CMs. Manoj Naravane, the quietest person in the course, among those hurly-burly Khalsas? He'll surely get eaten alive! One of them, Rajat Das, leaned over and whispered, 'Excellent unit, it's at Gangtok, Sikkim. My father is the Brigade Commander there. Plays bridge with your Commanding Officer.' That lifted my morale—Gangtok, Sikkim—exotic locations full of adventure; exactly what I had joined the Army for. And as I pen down these words, that feeling of adventure still runs strong, although I am retired now, as do the words of my coursemate. In hindsight, I could not have got a better unit or Regiment. Lady Luck sent me to Lucky Seven.

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